

INVENTING A PUBLIC ANTHROPOLOGY WITH LATINO FARM LABOR ORGANIZERS IN NORTH CAROLINA

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In this article, I summarize my experience conducting “an experiment in public anthropology” involving ethnographic fieldwork on a labor union struggle from the standpoint of volunteer work with community advocates for farm labor rights in North Carolina between 1998 and 2004. Theoretical rationales for participatory action research, issues of access, pros and cons from an information-gathering perspective, and ethical perspectives are discussed. Keywords: ethnography, farm labor, immigration, public anthropology

Since 1998, I have taken part in several projects involving collaboration with Latino workplace advocates that I have considered “experiments in public anthropology.” In this article, I draw on experience gained from two of these projects to discuss the risks and benefits of collaborative or “participatory action” research in which the researcher aligns herself with a grassroots organization or social movement engaged in political advocacy.

Both projects discussed in this article supported the campaign by the Farm Labor Organizing Committee (FLOC), a union founded in Ohio, to organize farmworkers in North Carolina. In the first project, I initiated and carried out a research and documentary project on working conditions on farms and the new FLOC campaign, with support from the Institute for Southern Studies (ISS), a progressive, research-focused nonprofit group. Afterward, I used the contacts and educational materials we had generated to start a local community-based farm labor support group at a Unitarian Universalist congregation. Our committee then leveraged funds for a statewide educational outreach project that is ongoing a decade later, and has enjoyed significant grant and institutional support.

I was inspired to collaborate with the union after learning about the labor rights abuses that typify farmwork. At one of my first meetings with union organizers in June 1998, the agenda was disrupted by news that a group of workers in Lenoir County had used the cover of a nighttime rain storm the previous evening to flee from the farm of a grower who they said forced them to work for 14 hours with only a half-hour break and refused to let sick workers rest. A month later, Carmelo Fuentes, a 37-year-old Mexican man, suffered a heat stroke in the fields, leaving him in a coma with fatal brain damage. After he collapsed in 90-plus degree temperatures, supervisors failed to call an ambulance until hours later. For three weeks leading up the incident, he had been working 6–7 day

weeks of 12-hour days. I met his father, who tended his son's limp body in a ward at the University of North Carolina Memorial Hospital, a few weeks before Carmelo was flown home to Mexico. Since then I have learned that farm labor advocates encounter several cases of serious injuries, heat strokes, and deaths in the North Carolina fields each growing season.

Today, Spanish speakers make up over 90 percent of farmworkers in the state, which also became home in the 1990s to the largest broker importing so-called guest workers from Mexico through the federal H2A visa program. Between 1990 and 2000 North Carolina led the nation as the destination of choice for Latino immigrants. The Spanish-speaking population rose fourfold in a decade, as people fled declining economies in Mexico and Central America (Saenz 2004). Many of these new workers were drawn to the state because of jobs in farmwork and in meat processing. The new population of workers, unable to speak English, fearful of deportation, and unaware of their civil or labor rights, has been especially vulnerable to exploitation.

I was also inspired by the new farmworker-organizing effort that FLOC began in 1997, directed at the growers of Mt. Olive Pickle Co., the second largest supermarket shelf pickle producer in the United States. Bill Bryan, the CEO of Mt. Olive, maintained that because he contracted with growers and did not hire farmworkers directly, he had no responsibility to them. From 1999–2004, FLOC organized a boycott of Mt. Olive pickles, which was eventually endorsed by over 300 organizations nationally. In 2004, FLOC achieved a ground-breaking contract with Mt. Olive and the state's large H2A "guest worker" program that imported three-quarters of the workers on farms selling to Mt. Olive.

ETHNOGRAPHIC INTERVENTIONS AND SOCIAL JUSTICE

The research methods I adopted might be described as a form of "critical ethnography," which D. Soyini Madison defines as starting from "an ethical responsibility to address processes of injustice within a particular *lived* domain," drawing on "moral principles of human freedom and well-being, and hence a compassion for the suffering of living beings" (2005:5). On questions of a researcher's positioning, she encouraged orientations for ethnographic work that resist "domestication" or complaisance, and thereby disrupt the *status quo* of inequality reinforced by colonial or imperial power relations (Madison 2005).

According to Michelle Fine (1994), what distinguishes such a critical, engaged approach from conventional approaches is the researcher's alignment with a specific political position, which gives the research project the potential to become a form of intervention—seeking to expose the effects of domination, while offering alternatives (Madison 2005:6). Madison draws on an analysis by Fine (1994), itself likely influenced by Jürgen Habermas (1971), that distinguishes this form of qualitative research from more conventional forms of cultural anthropology such as what she calls (1) the "ventriloquist stance," which seeks to transmit information from a neutral position, erasing

the role of the ethnographer (the form that dominated in the field up until the 1970s); and (2) the more contemporary stance of channeling–interpreting “positioned voices,” in which the ethnographer is more conscious and interested in disparate power relations yet keeps the focus on subaltern subjects and seeks to communicate indigenous meanings and experiences.

Although Habermas (1971) approached scholarly ethics from the standpoint of Marxist concerns about hegemonic relations of advanced capitalism, Madison’s scholarship, and much of Fine’s work, is grounded in African American studies (see also Harrison et al. 1991), and both also draw on feminist studies, which Kristen Esterberg (2002) credits with reshaping how anthropologists think about ethnographic ethics. So clearly there are multiple traditions within the social sciences that argue for aligning research in ways that strengthen the powerless, including collaboration with grassroots organizations seeking social change (see Philippe Bourgois 2002; Lesley Gill 2005; Luke Lassiter 2005; and June Nash 2005, 2007; for more recent writings on engaged or collaborative research).

Although collaborative approaches are common in applied anthropology, it is only in recent years that practitioners in the field have recovered from the stigma of association with colonialist or neoliberal development agencies, which were frequently the grist of development critiques in the 1980s and 1990s. Jason Paient (2007), in a recent review of anthropology and development, concludes that failures of development projects, combined with popular and social science critiques have been influential in persuading large agencies, including the World Bank, to rethink paternalistic approaches. He documented steady increases in numbers of anthropologists working in development in recent years and a shift away from ideological projects toward more pragmatic analyses, which often involve collaboration with local NGOs.

Since the 1970s, progressive development anthropologists have led in theorizing and testing such collaborative approaches, more commonly known as Participatory Action Research, defined by Esterberg (2002:137) as researchers collaborating with social struggles in processes that are designed to be “useful” not only in the typical academic sense of generating knowledge, but also in more concrete ways, such as accompaniment of organizers for their own protection, producing reports or educational materials specifically designed to aid social organizing, generating media articles, doing media outreach, or testifying before a court or tribunal.

As someone trained in medical anthropology, I made a conscious decision not to undertake a study of the occupational health of farmworkers from the perspective of ethnographic interviews in a health clinic because I knew that relatively few immigrant farmworkers gain access to migrant clinics, for a host of reasons, including cultural attitudes about machismo and illness, and lack of information, transport, or employer support. Also, I knew that federal dollars for migrant clinics averaged only about \$14 per worker, making the system ill equipped to serve the population’s need. Further, many conditions affecting the workers such as pesticide exposure and tobacco illness mimic other illnesses like the flu or overexposure to the sun, and fool workers into ignoring their symptoms (National Migrant Resource Program [NMRP] 1994). As Merrill Singer et al. (1998) noted, chronic problems suffered by immigrant workers have complex causes,

that include structural inequities, and, therefore, the theoretical framework for a critical medical anthropology (referring to scholarship guided by a focus on disparities in power within health and medicine) must incorporate macro as well as microlinkages.

I chose to focus instead on workers' experiences in the workplace, the union's efforts to advocate for them, and the complex politics and structural inequities behind the high rate of death and occupational injury on farms. The problem any researcher of farm labor encounters is access to sites and actors where key decision making about working conditions and immigrant labor take place. Both growers and agribusiness processors fear bad press, and many farmers who hire immigrants have long histories of trying to stay below the radar of government inspectors. Farm labor advocates often enter the public sphere in confrontation with growers and corporate agents, which leads to disputes over the "facts" surrounding immigrant workplaces.

Edward Liebow, writing about ethnography of controversial issues, suggested that researchers deal with such fraught situations by finding ways to "get inside the decision-making process" (2002:301). I had previously done research on rural health in El Salvador after that country's civil war (Smith-Nonini 1997a, 1997b), and one of the most productive experiences of ethnography I had there was while sitting in on a series of negotiations between popular health workers from a formerly rebel-controlled area and government health authorities. Partly as a result of my experiences in El Salvador, I came to see the FLOC campaign and the many public spaces of dialogue and confrontation that it created as a similar rich vein of information, in which the interactions and modes of communication between actors would carry relevance, every bit as meaningful as scientific "facts." The union struggle created a wedge of visibility on previously hidden transcripts (Scott 1990) between actors at disparate ends of the power spectrum.

My approach to public anthropology in the farmworker projects also involved grant writing, production of educational materials for use on literature tables, writing for the media and press outreach work, as well as scores of slide and video presentations in public settings. The staff of the ISS aided me in learning grant writing for social causes, but I already had some competence in writing for the media because of a former career in journalism from 1981–91.

THE "DOCUMENTING FARMWORKER STRUGGLES" PROJECT

My involvement began in mid-1998 after a chance encounter with an NFWM volunteer who told me about the new FLOC campaign. I had just completed my Ph.D. and was looking for a way to do research on Spanish-speaking populations without international travel because I had a ten-year-old son in school. I approached the research director of the ISS and suggested a documentary project on North Carolina farmworkers. He agreed, and I spent several months researching the issue using written materials, phone interviews and visits to advocacy organizations, state offices and farmworker camps, with the goal of producing an investigative report, fact sheets, a slide show, and media articles. At the beginning of our project we drew up an agreement between ISS, FLOC, and the

NFWM stating our intentions and the efforts we would make to do outreach to the media and community groups with the materials we produced. The agreement stated that ISS would retain editorial control over the product, and it allocated a number of published reports and slide shows that would be available to the union and the NFWM either free or at a discount.

The findings of the report that I authored entitled “Uprooting Injustice” concluded that high profitability of North Carolina crops had failed to translate into better pay and working conditions for farmworkers. In terms of agricultural profits, corporate restructuring had helped boost North Carolina’s rank, so the state was competing with big long-time leaders like Florida by 1990, yet the values of farmworker salaries, adjusted for inflation, had actually decreased since the 1970s. The average farmworker earned less than \$8,000 per year.

The report also cited federal data showing dramatically lower life expectancies for farmworkers, compared with other groups in the United States, and discussed how chronic exposure to poisonous pesticides, combined with other occupational hazards, created this situation.

I found that most North Carolina farmworkers lived in run-down housing with no heat or air conditioning, and inadequate water or sewage facilities. Despite reform legislation on housing and pesticide safety, enforcement of these regulations in North Carolina was (and continues to be) extremely poor. In interviews, the staff of state agencies were frank with me about the limitations they faced because of low funding and lack of political will from state legislators. For example, only a handful of safety inspectors served tens of thousands of farms, and in 1998 state agencies had almost no bilingual staff.

Because farmworkers fear deportation, and desperately need to send money back to their families in Mexico, they are an easily intimidated workforce that makes few demands on employers. Federal labor laws specifically exclude agricultural workers from most workplace protections that other Americans take for granted; therefore, during a harvest, farmworkers are often ordered to work 10- and 12-hour days, and 6–7 day weeks with no overtime pay. On top of this, small farms in North Carolina are legally permitted to pay less than minimum wage.

Because federal law does not guarantee rights of collective bargaining to farmworker unions, it is difficult for organized farmworkers to maintain a strike—growers can simply fire or seek deportation of undocumented workers and replace them with other, more desperate migrants. That is why Cesar Chavez’s United Farm Workers (UFW) developed strategies of public demonstrations and community boycotts (Edid 1994). During the 1970s the UFW made significant gains for West Coast union members, who won contracts under which fast workers could earn up to \$20 per hour, or close to triple the average farm labor wage in North Carolina, although workers saw many of their gains eroded under the conservative administration of Governor George Deukmejian in the 1980s (Ferris and Sandoval 1997).

In the late 1980s, FLOC also achieved fairer working agreements for 7,000 farmworkers in Michigan and Ohio following an eight-year boycott against Campbell Soup. FLOC achieved three-way contracts among processors, vegetable growers, and farmworkers that

gradually brought more dignity to Midwest farmworkers' living and working conditions. Farmers also came out well from FLOC's contracts in the Midwest, in that they received a larger price for their crops from the processors, which reap the largest share of profits under the vertical integration that has come to characterize agribusiness in the neoliberal era. FLOC also worked with state governments, processors, and growers in the Midwest to improve farmworkers' access to health care and affordable housing, and the union set up privately managed grievance procedures to resolve disputes on individual farms under contract.

At the ISS, we published the "Uprooting Injustice" report bilingually, and over 6,000 copies were distributed nationwide. Then in the spring of 1999, we conducted a campaign of media outreach to coincide with a local FLOC protest march. This led to dozens of contacts with reporters, many of whom wrote articles. Our report and outreach helped spur coverage in the *Raleigh News and Observer*, the *Los Angeles Times*, and an investigative series in the *Charlotte Observer* in the months that followed; and we assisted with a *Human Rights Watch* report on farm labor. I also wrote articles based on the ISS report that ran in the *Independent Weekly*, a regional independent newspaper, the ISS's *Southern Exposure* magazine and several other publications. The ISS institutionalized the "Farmworker Justice Project" for several years after that, hiring summer interns and, then a full time organizer.

THE IMPORTANCE OF COMMUNITY ORGANIZING

Churches, universities, and community groups were critical to the success of the FLOC campaign targeting Campbell's Soup in the Midwest during the 1980s. In the end, it was the combination of the boycott and the moral pressure from the surrounding community that forced Campbell executives to sit down at the bargaining table with farmworkers who picked tomatoes or cucumbers for farms selling to Campbell's. After the campaign, company officials acknowledged that letters and calls from church people had been critical in persuading company CEOs to negotiate. FLOC President Baldemar Velasquez won a McArthur Genius Award for his innovative three-way contracts achieved through the agreement that brought not only farm laborers and farmers but also the processor, into the agreement. Such public outreach and recognition is especially important in the neoliberal business environment in which processors have gained increasing control over the economics of farming in a political environment that has been hostile to organized labor.

As they did in the Midwest, FLOC organizers in North Carolina chose to focus their boycott campaign on the industry leader, which is Mt. Olive for cucumbers. In Ohio and Michigan, contracts with Vlasic and Heinz had followed rapidly after FLOC won the Campbell's contract. Velasquez argued that since other companies must compete with Mt. Olive, it would be much easier to obtain contracts with them once the union had the biggest brand name under contract. An important aspect of FLOC strategy was that by organizing cucumber pickers, FLOC was also organizing tobacco and sweet potato

pickers. These crops have overlapping growing seasons and all three crops tend to be grown on many of the large tobacco farms in eastern North Carolina, which retain the same set of workers all season. These are by far the state's largest farms and the sites where most of the state's farmworkers are employed. Three-quarters of the workers picking cucumbers for Mt. Olive turned out to be H2A workers brought in with seasonal visas through the federal H2A program.¹ By the end of the 1990s, North Carolina had the largest H2A program in the country, and much of the media coverage that we helped generate focused on abuses associated with this large, state-sanctioned, but privately brokered "guest worker" program.

At the beginning of FLOC's campaign, the NFWM sent a pair of volunteers to organize in rural areas, but it became rapidly apparent that they were having only limited success—antiunion sentiment and racism has remained prevalent in the rural South, along with understandable loyalty to farmers and the agricultural processors that are the main source of economic growth in many areas. A few churches provided facilities for Spanish services; others participated in service work and charity directed at Mexican immigrants. But many others had conservative congregations with a large number of farm families who had seen hard times themselves and resented the presence of union organizers concerned with the plight of workers who were not U.S. citizens.

To give an example, in August 1998 Baldemar Velasquez and three former farmworkers volunteering with FLOC were arrested for trespassing while visiting a work camp on the farm of a Nash County grower who employed H2A workers. The North Carolina Growers Association (NCGA), which ran the state's H2A guest worker program, did not recognize any tenancy rights for farmworkers and routinely denied them rights to invite visitors onto labor camps. Local law enforcement tended to side with growers. Although a judge threw the case out, afterward the sheriff said he would continue arresting organizers who growers accused of "trespassing." Thus one of our goals in public education was to build a sense of solidarity and community between the migrants isolated in these rural camps and middle-class citizens who benefit from their labor every time they enter a grocery store.

THE ONGOING UNITARIAN UNIVERSALIST OUTREACH PROJECT

For all these reasons, I looked for an opportunity to start a local support group. I was pleased to learn of a call for proposals for a year-long social justice project at Eno River Unitarian Universalist Fellowship (ERUUF) in Durham. Our support group began as a volunteer task force in 1999, which focused on the congregation itself, during a six-month educational effort. The congregation voted both to undertake a long-term project on farmworkers and also went on record in support of the FLOC boycott. This outreach and public education project continues today with an office and full-time staff person.

In 1999 we sought grant support from the denomination's Unitarian Universalist Funding Program (UUF) for a statewide educational project on farm labor. This proposal resulted in \$9,500 in grant and matching funds. We then worked out a collaboration between the NFWM and ERUUF to combine funds for a full-time staff person, who did

outreach to “people of faith” throughout the state, arranged educational presentations at churches and community groups, and led visits to farmworker camps each summer in collaboration with FLOC organizers. Our support group also led frequent pickets at Kroger stores, asking them to take Mt. Olive pickles off their shelves. In 2001 we organized a well-attended public debate between Bill Bryan, the CEO of Mt. Olive, and Baldemar Velasquez, of FLOC. The event, held in a Raleigh Baptist church, generated a spate of local news articles, including our first coverage by the *New York Times*, and a program about the campaign that aired on *North Carolina NOW*, a statewide TV news-magazine show.

Our UUFP grant was renewed, and in 2001–02, with help from two filmmakers who joined our group, we produced an hour-long video entitled *Help Wanted: Farmworkers in North Carolina*, which aired on public access television in several North Carolina cities. Over 300 copies were sold to organizers and educators around the country. Our staff obtained funding from separate grants to support a two-week summer work camp in Greenville, North Carolina, to educate visiting delegations from other states about farmworkers’ social justice concerns, and we worked with the state’s Episcopal Farmworker Ministry to set up a “sistering” program that paired religious congregations with individual farm labor camps to build ongoing relationships through a series of activities during each growing season. Since then, the UUFP funds have been renewed, although at smaller levels, three more times, and the project has continued to receive annual social justice funds from the ERUUF congregation.

Although activities of the ERUUF task force and outreach office were independent of FLOC, we made the decision after much debate to actively support the boycott as one of our central activities. We considered a focus on legislative action because the state has weak laws protecting agricultural workers and poor enforcement of existing regulations. But veterans of farmworker advocacy convinced us that past efforts to win gains for farm labor through the state’s conservative and farm-friendly legislature had never borne fruit. States that have adopted more farmworker-friendly legislation on the West Coast and the Midwest have usually done so because of the advocacy of a farm labor union. Given the underfunded system of state labor inspectors, we opted for a strategy of building a union to strengthen farmworker knowledge and oversight of regulations at each labor camp.²

COMMUNITY ORGANIZING AND THE FARMWORKER STRUGGLE

It is always difficult to quantify the impact of community organizing in social justice work, but in the absence of organization, farmworkers have rarely won struggles with the influential agricultural industry. Here, speaking from my perspective as a member of a farm labor advocacy group, we initially measured our effectiveness in numbers of churches and community organizations to which we did outreach and numbers of educational presentations and labor camp visits carried out. Between the staff person and our committee of volunteers, we sponsored dozens of educational events each year. Letter-writing to CEO Bill Bryan was one of the activities in which we encouraged groups to engage. One effect of this was a constant effort by Bryan to counter our educational

efforts. He hired a full-time public relations person who answered letters with packets of Mt. Olive literature, and who also frequently contacted organizations where we or FLOC spoke or planned to speak, asking to either share the stage or come at a later date to tell their side of the story, which emphasized Mt. Olive being separate from the farmers that hire workers, and in no position to tell them what to do. In contrast, in our talks we discussed the strong leverage Mt. Olive wielded over farmers, including the company setting prices for the harvest and regulating the inputs used in cucumber farming.

Although the picket lines at store fronts and letter writing to Kroger did not bear immediate fruit locally, it did in northern Ohio, where a coalition of unions and municipal officials convinced Kroger to remove Mt. Olive products from its stores. This, and negotiations by FLOC with two other grocery store chains, turned out to be key factors influencing Bryan to sign the contract with FLOC in 2004.

Students at Duke University formed a group called Duke Students against Sweatshops and mounted protests asking campus food services to stop carrying Mt. Olive pickles. In March 2002 Duke University President Nan Keohane announced that Duke would boycott Mt. Olive products. In a letter to the students, Keohane cited a history of reported abuses against farmworkers and said “We believe it is incumbent upon Mt. Olive Pickle Co. to take a more proactive role in investigating these situations and holding their suppliers to adequate standards.”³ Unfortunately, after a flurry of meetings with Bryan and his supporters over the summer, and a pledge of good treatment for farmworkers, Keohane rescinded the campus boycott the following August. As a former Duke alumnus, I sought and was granted a meeting with Keohane for a delegation from our Unitarian Universalist (UU) support committee, to express our views and hear her rationale for Duke’s decision to “work around” the union. Unfortunately, this was near the end of Keohane’s tenure as president, and the labor issue was put on the back burner by the next administration.

In 2002, FLOC moved the union office from the small town of Faison into a Mexican store on the outskirts of Goldsboro where they enjoyed more frequent contact with the local Latino community. The union decided to focus actively on the needs of Spanish-speaking residents who live and work in the region year-round. FLOC began holding well-attended monthly forums addressing worker issues and offered English as a Second Language classes, legal aid, and worker’s rights workshops.

An incident in 2003 illustrated the strength of the new solidarity the union achieved with year-round immigrants. In late May, a farmworker named Manuel Ortiz fell ill with acute abdominal pain on a Wayne County farm that produced cucumbers for Mt. Olive.⁴ The crew leader—a Mexican immigrant—refused to take Ortiz to a hospital, so nine of his fellow workers pooled their own funds to call a taxi. If they had not done so, Ortiz would have died. His life was saved by an emergency appendectomy. But, rather than celebrating, the crew leader was angry that Ortiz could not work after the surgery yet continued to take up a bed in the labor camp. Relations with the crew leader worsened, according to the men, who said he refused to give them pay stubs and threatened them with a pistol. Finally he fired the entire group, refusing to pay them for their last three days’ work.

Dozens of similar incidents of abuses and unpaid wages come to the attention of farmworker advocates each summer. Most are not officially reported and go unresolved because migrants are afraid to challenge their bosses. But this episode turned out differently. The workers visited the nearby FLOC office, where union organizers helped them pull together a 40-person delegation of local Hispanics. The group paid the mens' former boss a visit at his home on the evening of June 19. Surprised by the demonstration of support, the crew leader quickly agreed to pay the workers the nearly \$1,000 they were owed. He counted out the cash for each on the spot. In telling me the story, FLOC organizer Matt Emmick observed, "It took a collective action to get this short-term gain, but for long-term gains, we need collective bargaining."

One important move FLOC made around this time was to replace its former coordinator for the Mt. Olive campaign, who had poor English skills and was an ineffective public speaker, with Leticia Zavala, an energetic young woman from Florida, who grew up in a farmworker family, and had worked in the fields herself for much of her childhood. Her father had been an organizer for the union, and she, herself, only escaped a life of manual labor thanks to FLOC's assistance in gaining her mother a settlement for a work-related disability, with which she started a small restaurant. After that Leticia attended college with aid from a scholarship for minorities, majoring in sociology. Leticia has become my favorite example of an "organic" intellectual, the term used by Antonio Gramsci (1971) for grassroots leaders who develop sophisticated, and often uniquely positioned, analyses of a political struggle. She rapidly became FLOC's most tireless worker, and after the 2004 contract was signed with Mt. Olive, she was elected vice president of the union.

Many FLOC supporters were caught by surprise in the summer of 2004 when union leaders began a series of meetings with workers in preparation for negotiations with Bryan and the head of the North Carolina Growers Association, which ran the H2A guest worker program. One event thought to have pushed Bryan to negotiate was the recent decision by the Methodist Church to join the boycott. Bryan, a Methodist, had campaigned against the resolution at the denomination's General Assembly that spring. Also, Velasquez had begun talks with two other supermarket chains about removing Mt. Olive pickles from their stores in the Midwest.

The most important aspects of the contract, renewed in 2007 and 2008, included the new grievance procedures (which have been heavily used), provisions allowing workers to leave earlier at the end of the season, and more transportation options for workers, who previously had to remain on farms for weeks after the end of full-time work, and take buses to Mexico contracted by the growers' association. Since the contract, it has been exciting to witness the growth of the now 8,000-strong union and gradual empowerment of workers at union meetings. Because North Carolina is a "right to work" state that forbids a closed shop, FLOC was obligated to organize statewide with new outreach to H2A guest workers in the apple and Christmas tree industries in western North Carolina counties. This presented a logistical challenge, which has been met through organizing an enormous carpool network for transporting workers to union meetings, and which involved over 200 drivers, many of them based in churches.

One of the precedent-setting aspects of FLOC's work since 2004 has been their transnational organizing. FLOC is the first U.S.-based union to open a permanent field office in Mexico. This originated when workers at union meetings in 2005 called on FLOC to defend them from corrupt practices by H2A recruiters in Mexico who many claimed ran scams to extorted large sums of money from workers in exchange for the right to enter the H2A program. The following spring, FLOC won a lawsuit against the growers' association over these excess fees. A tragic downside to this was the April 2007 murder of Santiago Rafael Cruz in FLOC's Monterrey, Mexico, office, widely thought to have been carried out by human traffickers whose profits were hurt by the lawsuit.

In 2007, FLOC turned its attention to a new campaign focused on Reynolds Tobacco in Winston-Salem. Although it took five years before the CEO of Mt. Olive responded to moral pressure, the lesson of that campaign seems to have been taken to heart at Reynolds. So far, the Reynolds CEO has refused to meet with FLOC, but corporate managers did agree to meet with a group of black ministers who interceded on behalf of the union. Told of the hundreds of complaints from farmworkers afflicted each season from Green Tobacco Sickness, a common ailment caused by nicotine poisoning from handling the plants (Quandt et al. 2000), Reynolds initiated several meetings at university medical centers pushing for more research on the illness. So it is significant that even at this early stage of the campaign, FLOC has spurred Reynolds managers to act on the premise that the corporation has a social obligation to the immigrant workers whose labor produces the tobacco.

REFLECTIONS ON COMBINING ACTIVISM AND ANTHROPOLOGY

When doing research on issues such as migrant labor or union struggles, the most basic research requirement—access to the workers and information about the conflict—is problematic. Bosses are not sympathetic to outsiders talking with “their” workers, and in any labor struggle, contract negotiations are kept secret. By deciding to learn about the issue from the perspective of the union and worker advocates, I gained access to workers and to details of the struggles. My presence in rural areas was nearly always welcomed by organizers as a form of accompaniment—a supporter from an urban area was seen as shoring up organizers' credibility, and I was a witness in case of trouble with crew leaders or farmers.

As a university-based anthropologist working with the UU outreach project, the programs of camp visits were extremely useful, providing transportation to and access to labor camps as well as social occasions at which it was relatively easy and productive to interview workers. Often I served as a translator for oral interviews with church members, and I conducted more detailed interviews on the sidelines during group meals and other activities. I was open about my position as a researcher with workers who spoke with me, and I do not use the real names or other identifying features of immigrant informants in publications.

There were downsides to my decision to author the “Uprooting Injustice” report in the first year of the union’s campaign. Shortly after the report came out, I was seen by Bryan and the head of the NCGA as a worker advocate, rather than a researcher. This created tension and made it difficult for me to hold productive interviews with them or gain access to their worlds. I often wished for a research partner, so that one of us could concentrate on the workers, and the other on the growers and processors.

In working with the union, I tried to present a different face of the academy to labor leaders. Velasquez was openly critical of elitism among university researchers, who are often not committed or helpful to labor struggles. His perspective was understandable, as I sometimes found myself letting local organizing responsibilities slide because of the time pressures of my academic job. I have shared all my writings about the campaign with Velasquez and his staff and have sought opinions on drafts, but only rarely have I received editorial feedback, because of the time pressures that keep an underfunded labor union’s staff constantly on the move.

One downside of collaborative work is that a scholar is unlikely to feel willing to engage in a frank critique of an organization with which she has worked closely. On the one hand, this would be more of a dilemma in a situation in which the organization in question turns out to be undemocratic or corrupt. I have not encountered any major unethical practices by FLOC, which, while clearly guided by a charismatic leader, is a relatively democratic organization that responds to worker resolutions and staff feedback. On the other hand, my goal in the project was to use the union movement to understand the relations among farm labor, the state-sanctioned H2A program, and the food corporation at which the campaign was directed, rather than to study the union itself as an organization. Some scholars continue to see collaborative or participatory action research as inherently “biased.” When I submitted a research proposal to the Sage Foundation in 2007, for example, concerns about my collaboration with FLOC arose in one of the critiques written by an anonymous reviewer.

The timing of publication may become a strategic question in collaborative research on a controversial issue. Given the broad trust and access that FLOC gave me, while the Mt. Olive campaign was under way I decided against publishing any analysis of the organizing effort that dealt with issues of strategy or internal affairs of the union, both to assure confidentiality and privacy to my informants and to avoid my writings being used against the union by their adversaries, since the growers association and Mt. Olive Pickle Company engaged in many efforts to discredit the union and supporters. I am now planning a book project on the Mt. Olive campaign. FLOC has asked for a book that will be useful in educating future organizers, and I hope to produce a book that will serve those ends while also being useful in the classroom. But I have not been willing to give up editorial control to the union, which the existing union policy on working with academics (adopted since the 1998 ISS–FLOC collaboration) seems to require. I am hopeful that my collegial relationships with the union staff and leadership, and my argument that an independent account makes for a more credible book, will suffice to help me gain the additional detailed interviews such a project would entail.

In publishing about the H2A program, I initially faced a dilemma over whether to use a pseudonym for the director (and founder) of the growers' association. The North Carolina Growers' Association, while registered as a nonprofit, actually paid taxes on annual revenues that media reports estimated at \$5 million. Because there was only one H2A brokerage in the state during the period of the study, even with use of a pseudonym, knowledgeable readers would be able to identify the individual in question. This is a classic dilemma of choosing to do research on the powerful, or what Laura Nader (1972) called "studying up." I decided to use a pseudonym in most writings for scholars although not in media articles, nor in the first social science article I wrote, which came out in a Mexican journal in Spanish. But I turned to a pseudonym over concerns of an editor (of a book collection to which I contributed a chapter) about risks of a libel suit, rather than over ethical concerns. As a former journalist, I believe that the ethics of public disclosure of abuses sometimes trumps the ethnographic ethic of protecting privacy of informants. In addition, the rather outspoken informant had already become a public figure through being quoted and his practices critiqued in numerous media articles that preceded my publications.

Although writing for the media may be challenging at first for a scholar more accustomed to lengthy tomes, it is a learnable skill that any educated person can master, and that will stand one in good stead with future journal and book editors. I agree with Alan Campbell's (1996) refusal to buy into the traditional academic dismissal of popularizing texts and applaud his suggestion that more professors (and tenure committees) should value the art of writing for a popular readership and work toward building such challenges into university reward systems.

Many busy scholars may hesitate to engage in collaborative ethnography because of the time commitment involved combining research with organizing. In this case, I feel that the time investment was worthwhile because of the value of the organizing effort itself, and the resulting quality of the research. It also paid off through grant support. The initial documentary project with the ISS laid groundwork for a successful proposal for a year-long postdoctoral grant and helped me secure a \$5,000 Public Service Grant from the University of North Carolina for a related project on Latino meatpacking workers.⁵

But the most important reason to do this kind of collaboration for me was personal. I have always felt that one of the attractive aspects of university life and of anthropology was the possibility of doing research and writing on things that matter. I have found collaboration with labor organizers very satisfying to my need to bring the work of the academy more in touch with the community and with struggles for social justice.

NOTES

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1. This was determined initially through field research by FLOC organizers who followed trucks leaving the fields and cucumber grading stations to determine the relationships between

farms and processors, and to find the often hidden labor camps. It was confirmed by Mt. Olive CEO Bill Bryan and supported by figures from the North Carolina Department of Labor on locations of farms using H2A workers.

2. Only recently, in 2007, have farm labor advocates achieved a mild reform in migrant housing rules. A key component of this law, which required farm owners to provide mattresses for workers, led to the legislation being dubbed “the mattress bill,” which embarrassed conservative supporters of corporate agriculture.

3. This quote is taken from copy of the letter provided by Duke Students against Sweatshops.

4. Pseudonyms are used for farmworkers in this account.

5. This was a \$30,000 grant funded by the Mellon Foundation, as part of a 1999–2000 Mellon-Sawyer Seminar in the International Studies program at the University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill.

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